‘That’s murder,’ I said.

‘Medical protocol, sir,’ the doctor said.

I pleaded that the baby to be kept on the ventilator for some more days.

‘How many more days?’

‘Five more days,’ I said.

There was no basis to my saying five more days. The number just came to my mind as one that the doctors may agree to. And they did.

The infant’s condition rapidly deteriorated after three days on the ventilator. And, on the second day of my borrowed time, her second lung, too, was affected. How many more days can we keep her on the machine? Where do we go for the mounting hospital bill? There was only one person to go to. I called Mademoissile Mary.

‘Can you help us save a baby?

Mary readily agreed. But, again, the question of how many days cropped up. I repeated, ‘five more’.

Mary asked me what after that. I said I don’t know. Just that I didn’t want to be a party to the decision to pull the plug. My wife kept telling me that I should never allow that. ‘Maybe break the rules, confront people, beg or borrow,’ she said. That’s exactly what I have been doing.

Mary kept footing the bill and, on the second day, the baby’s health started improving. They soon healed. In a couple of days, she was off the ventilator. Today, she is a successful professional in Bangalore. Thirty-seven years later, in 2012, at an apparel showroom in Thiruvananthapuram (earlier Trivandrum), a mother and daughter walked up to me.

‘Do you remember me?’ asked the older woman.

‘Sorry, I can’t recollect.’

‘What about my daughter? Do you remember her?’

‘No,’ I said.

The woman identified herself as the wife of a scientist who worked in my team in Vernon. “And this is my daughter born in Paris.’

I was not sure if she knew that her daughter had come back from the jaws of death soon after her birth.